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A troublesome trifecta in Triplicane



Can you take these three issues and resolve them for us? That is the question residents of the locality have for candidates

PRINCE FREDERICK

Triplicane can do without this trifecta of pains: stray cattle, unauthorised parking on roads around Sri Parthasarathy temple and petty shops that threaten to outnumber dwelling units. When issues fester for decades, people get inured to them, accommodate them, and learn to conduct the regular transactions of life around these pain points. These issues can get normalised to the point they seem non-existent until they raise their deadly horns again. And then these issues receive air time, only to get normalised again. T.J. Ramani is a key member of Srinivas Young Men's Association (SYMA). What "The Alley Project" has meant to Detroit, SYMA means to Triplicane. Ramani weighs in with three issues of this kind.

Not a 'petty' problem

Ramani wants Greater Chennai Corporation to enforce strict zoning discipline that would prevent the proliferation of petty shops in residential areas. While commercialisation of residential spaces is not restricted to Triplicane, this problem has prickly spikes as the streets in the locality are narrow. And this issue completes the trifecta of pains, each connected with the streets of Triplicane.

A problem wheeled in

The Parthasarathy temple is one of the pivot points in Triplicane, and a sizeable part of the locality revolves around it. Ramani says the lack of a parking infrastructure is exposed during festivals and seasons that encourage temple visits. Vehicles are certain to be parked in front of residential gates.

In his eyes, there are two solutions. One, the HR&CE Department making use of temple land to have a parking facility constructed; and two, Greater Chennai Corporation building a multi-level parking facility in Triplicane that would benefit visitors to the temple as well as beach-goers. He is for the second option due to the wider benefits it would offer.

PHOTO : S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

A problem with horns

Established in 1977 by a bunch of youngsters fired with a desire to improve Triplicane, SYMA has locked horns with one issue, stray cattle moving about Triplicane as if they were part of the traffic. And they are still locking horns with this issue.

He calls it a "critical and unresolved issue" in Triplicane, noting that it has spanned "five election cycles", actually more. SYMA would once again present this peeve to candidates in the fray for the Assembly elections. In January 2025, while taking to *The Hindu* on how to resolve this knotty problem, Ramani had expressed skepticism over GCC's approach to rein in the stray cattle issue by building cattle sheds without studying the issue.

That January, 2025 report in *The Hindu* had also quoted a GCC worker as pointing out that despite a cattle shed functioning under the MRTS tracks in Triplicane, the streets in the locality continued to be "well-hoofed". The worker had underlined an attitude among cattle owners in Triplicane: leave the old cows in the shed, and leave the younger ones loose. The report explained that they were emboldened to do this as the penalty system is not being strictly enforced. It brandished data provided by GCC's Public Health department, showing no cattle owner guilty of letting a cow loose on pedestrians "has been fined ₹15,000 yet". As a new GCC cattle shed is in the works at Narayana Krishanaraja Puram (known as Krishnapuram), it would help to remember that the "shed-and-dread" formula alone will rid Triplicane of this stubborn problem. Offer cattle owners sheds to keep their cattle, and make them dread the possibility of a hefty fine if they think they and their cattle own the streets.



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Thambi K. Parthasarathy (on the mike); and dubbing artiste E.M.S. Murali (standing); and (below) the stall at North Mada Street. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



LIFFY THOMAS

Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit has added a fresh feather to its cap. On March 30, when the Mada Streets around Kapaleeswarar Temple in Mylapore were teeming with devotees for the Arubathimoovar procession, these volunteers took a strategic position, stationing themselves in the compound of Indian Bank on North Mada Street. Their presence equalled safely. With a public address system, they were continually urging devotees to keep their children safe in crowded spaces. By the end of the day, they had helped reunite three children with their parents. And 25 others who are in their second children: they are senior citizens.

"Two boys and one girl; and 25 senior citizens, some of them having difficulty walking," 76-year-old Thambi K. Parthasarathy spells out the details. Parthasarathy is a core member of Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit; his voice is hoarse from hours of shouting.

For more than a decade now, Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit, esta-

Rescue operation amidst the festivity

With a sea of devotees flowing through the Mada streets for the Arubathimoovar procession in Mylapore, these volunteers keep their voices primed for continual announcements

blished by Late M.G. Shankar, has made it a point to volunteer during the Arubathimoovar procession, the highlight of the Panguni festival, where thousands of devotees through the streets. Annadhanam is the core activity carried out by this informal group of friends who live in and around Mylapore. While performing a raft of activities, the unit adds a service to it, ensuring children do not go missing in the crowds by asking parents to be vigilant and when children do go missing, it finds and reunites children with their parents.

"It was Late T.C. Vijayan, former MLA and a member of the Unit, who suggested that we do this ser-

vice during the Panguni festival as the crowds are huge, and the loud-speaker was set up at only one point then," says Thambi Parthasarathy.

Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit has close to 120 members, and a majority of them have moved to other parts of the city, but they make it in attendance during Panguni.

In his early 70s and an active volunteer, Santhanam Krishnan moved from Mandaveli to Kottivakkam some years ago, but every year during Panguni he is around to support the volunteering effort.

"Late Shankar and I used to take a pilgrimage to Sabrimala Temple

in Kerala and he motivated me to get involved in the activities of the Unit," says Santhanam, who is president of the Unit, adding that they volunteer on a rotational basis.

With the permission of the temple management and the police, Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit got additional speakers installed at all the four mada veeadis for the announcements to be heard in all corners. The police has a booth near the temple where it does its own announcements. Currently, eight speakers are installed in each of the streets, all relayed from one point by volunteers. Over the years, the volunteers have tweaked the way they make the announcements,

thereby keeping the exercise from causing their throats harm.

"Some messages such as 'take care of jewellery', 'do not leave children alone', 'who to report if something is lost' are pre-recorded and relayed during the procession," says Thambi Parthasarathy, who is also secretary of Kalyan Nagar Association in Mandavelipakkam.

For the last two years, dubbing artistes have also joined the group to make announcements. There's M.S. Kabali, organising secretary, who coordinates with all stakeholders including police for permissions and other arrangements.

There are many heart-warming stories from the festival that keep this group continuing to do this service. Many senior citizens were united with their family members. Thambi Parthasarathy will not forget the case of a deaf and mute girl being brought to them some five years ago. "There was no way the five-year-old could understand what we were asking her or give us any info about her family members, so we made an announcement that provided details about the dress, footwear and accessories she was wearing. Her desperate parents who had looked high and low for her had gone to the police station where they were directed to us," says the Mandavelipakkam resident, adding that the 'there is a special joy in seeing people unite that cannot be expressed.'

Mylai Mandaveli Friends Unit has not kept a count of the number of children and elders they have reunited over the years, but they have started the exercise of data collection now. "In the last three years, I have been noting them down in my diary," he says, and puts the yearly average over the last three years, at 75 people reunited. In the light of that average, this year the Unit has done commendable work, as only 28 people had to be reunited.

A 'sketch' of a festival



Members of Chennai Weekend Artists were making impressions of the Panguni festival, taking in its sights. They based their 527th sketch meet entirely on the festival, as these three sketches from the meet show. .



Recent images of damaged seaters shared by Deepak; and (right) an image of a seater taken on February 27, 2026.

READERS WRITE

Seats at Gopalapuram pavement damaged



DEEPAK DORAIRAJ

After a long delay in laying the pavement in Gopalapuram, many of the seaters did not last long.

The photos illustrate the state of the seaters, marked by poor design and quality. One hopes the damaged seaters are replaced with ones designed better with sturdy materials.

Travel free on buses and trains to Chepauk

As in previous years, Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) and Chennai Metro Rail Limited have launched an initiative to reduce traffic congestion and encourage people to use public transport on IPL match days in the city.

People with IPL match tickets can travel free on MTC buses (whiteboard and deluxe) for three hours before and after the

match. After the match gets over, MTC will operate buses from Anna Square bus terminus, Island Grounds (temporary) bus terminus, University of Madras haltover and near Omandurar Hospital on Anna Salai. From Anna Statue on Mount Road, MTC will operate shuttle services to the cricket stadium.

Metro trains

People intending to travel on the

Metro should possess a valid match ticket, said a CMRL press release.

The ticket will enable a round-trip journey between their chosen stations and the Government Estate metro station.

Green line stations

The last train from the Government Estate metro station will depart at 1 a.m. towards Wimco Na-

gar Depot and Airport stations.

Commuters travelling towards green line stations (Corridor-2) shall interchange only at Chennai Central (during the special train services).

The entry to the Estate station will be restricted 10 minutes before the last train for each line. The matches are scheduled to be held at M. A. Chidambaram Cricket Stadium in Chepauk.

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Vivekananda College conducts seminar on 'AI for All'

The Entrepreneurship Development Cell of the Ramakrishna Mission Vivekananda College (Evening) in Mylapore, organised a day-long seminar on "AI for All & AI in MSME", on March 28, 2026, featuring industry leaders, successful founders, and senior officials from the Entrepreneurship Development and Innovation Institute, Tamil Nadu, Department of MSME, Government of Tamil Nadu.

Organised as a Scientific Social Responsibility (SSR) Programme (a Science-Society Connect Initiative) under a DST-FIST Supported Pro-

ject implemented by the Department of Computer Science, Ramakrishna Mission Vivekananda Educational and Research Institute, Belur Math, Howrah, the seminar drew participation from 40 students representing seven institutions across Chennai and 60 students from the College, in addition to faculty members and alumni, said a press release.

The seminar presented AI as a day-to-day companion rather than a challenge and instilled confidence in the potential of MSME for economic transformation, added the release.

Ayurveda and yoga centre in Mylapore

Vidhatri Stri Swasthya Manjari, an ayurveda and yoga centre in Mylapore, offers personalised lifestyle guidance for women's holistic health and well-being.

Women can seek advice for hormonal imbalances including PCOS, menopause, and irregular cycles; joint and musculoskeletal issues, stress and sleep problems, hair loss, skin issues, eye strain, digestive problems, fatigue, and health challenges related to urban living.

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SUMMER SALE IS ON 7TH & 8TH APRIL

Thughil, a store for handlooms is having a summer sale of curated handloom, cotton, natural-dyed saris, dress- material, ready-mades and Organic food.

The range includes Ajrakh prints, hand-block prints, Tie & dye and Pen-Kalamkari

The sale is on 7th & 8th at C.P.Arts Centre, Mini hall (1), Alwarpet. Contact no: 7395972701 Timings 10.30am to 7pm.

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Summer sale of handlooms

Thughil, a store for handlooms is having a summer sale of curated handloom, cotton, natural-dyed saris, dress material, readymades and organic food.

The range includes Ajrakh prints, hand-block prints, Tie & dye and Pen-Kalamkari

The sale is on April 7 and 8 at C.P. Arts Centre, Mini hall (1), Alwarpet. Contact no: 7395972701 Timings 10.30 a.m. to 7 p.m.

Free career-readiness course

Chevalier T. Thomas Elizabeth College for Women is conducting a series of free crash courses for girl students of class VIII onwards. The programme is scheduled to be conducted from April 7 to 10, between 9.30 a.m. and 1 p.m.

The initiative seeks to enhance students' employability skills, critical thinking, domain knowledge, and career readiness through practical and student-centred learning

approaches.

Sessions will be offered across a range of disciplines, including Tally and FinTech, MS Office and digital marketing, psychology, career guidance, current affairs, culture and personality development, and AI tools. Certificates will be issued to all participants upon successful completion of the programme.

For details, call the college office at 044 2537 5753

Cricket coaching camp



The Gandhi Nagar Cricket and Sports Club is conducting its Summer Coaching Camp 2026 at the Club's ground at No. 63-A, 4th Main Road in Gandhi Nagar, Adyar. Stretching from April 13 to May 29, the camp is for boys and girls in the age group six to 19. The coaching sessions will be from 6.15 a.m. to 8.15 a.m. For details, call C.S. Ravi, honorary secretary at 8754407654 / K. Balakrishnan, honorary joint secretary at 9444824838



During the panel discussion.

Cinema parsed against the backdrop of AI, OTT platforms

The Indian Society for Universal Dialogue, under the aegis of School of Excellence in Law organised a panel discussion titled 'Beyond Box Office: A Dialogue on Films, Society, & Law' at the Tagore Film Centre on Music College Road in Raja Anna-maipuram on March 29. The idea behind the conversation was: take a moment to introspect the impact of movies in society and its intersection with law.

A press release notes this session brought together an insightful panel comprising K Hariharan, a national award winning director and advocate Deepika Shyam from DS Legal moderated by Srinivasa Ramanujam, deputy editor, *The Hindu*. The press release says Srinivasa Ramanujam steered the conversation in a manner that unravelled layers of the film industry that often remain unnoticed. K Hariharan shared his opinion on limiting the use of AI for writing purposes, to fictionalise certain un-lived experiences, but not as a substitute for original creative expression while Deepika Shyam opined that

bringing in laws for governing OTT platforms might be difficult considering the transnational jurisdiction. The conversation delved into aspects of film making, audience coverage and censor boards whilst uncovering the complexities of roles played by the directors, writers/ writer box, and producers and their legal recognition while also discussing the socio-legal aspects of Indian Cinema.

The discussion was followed by a master-class by Hariharan titled "Who is afraid of Indian Cinema", wherein he recollected the making of *Ezhavathu Manithan*, a national award-winning film recounting the challenges in categorising such works as merely "art" or "award" films, asserting that such labels hinder the growth of a healthy and inclusive cinematic culture. He also drew comparisons with global industries such as Hollywood and Iranian cinema, and emphasised the role of law in protecting the artist's rights and freedom while bearing in mind the ambiguities in the current cinematography laws.

The Hindu EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair on April 11 and 12

The Hindu EducationPlus is conducting the 23rd edition of *The Hindu EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair* on April 11 and 12 from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m. at the Chennai Trade Centre, Convention Hall.

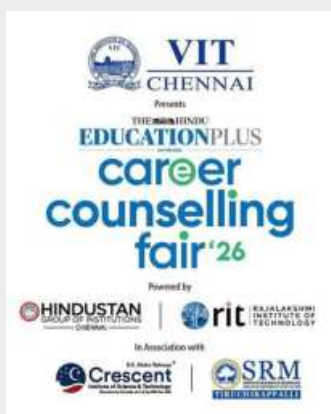
The exhaustive fair for parents and students from classes 9 to 12 will empower aspiring young minds to make informed career decisions from 40 plus institutions and help them choose the right courses and colleges.

Top educational and financial institutions from across India will be present. Furthermore, career guidance sessions with domain experts will help people discuss their career plans.

This annual fair is a great chance for students and parents to explore different career paths, learn about college admissions, and gain insights into various fields of study.

A plethora of options awaits students as they get ready to finish their schooling, much more than ever before. There are a wide range of courses to choose from, careers to aspire to, and areas of interest to delve into.

In every edition, the fair has aimed to give students insights into several areas, cater to their interests, and open a world of educational opportunities for them.



The latest edition of the career counselling fair will have all of this and make this experience possible for students by giving them the platform to engage with experts across diverse fields and representatives from various educational and financial institutions. Keeping up with the needs of the students, *The Hindu EducationPlus* has been organising career expos to aid students looking to pursue higher education both in India and overseas.

Spot admissions and scholarships await the students at the fair along with surprise gifts for the first 200 entries on both the days. To know more about the sessions and the fair, contact: +91 90940 41021, 9962226550 and 9841298938.

"VIT Chennai presents *The*

Hindu - Education Plus Career Counselling Fair 2026" is powered by Hindustan Group of Institutions, Chennai and Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology, In Association with B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science & Technology and SRM Institute of Science & Technology, Tiruchirapalli. Associate partners are Amet University, Bharath Institute of Higher Education and Research, GRT Institute of Engineering and Technology, Meenakshi Academy of Higher Education & Research (MAHER), Symbiosis Skills and Professional University, Pune, The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India, Vels Institute of Science, Technology & Advanced Studies (VISTAS) and Vinayaka Mission's Research Foundation, Chennai Campus.

To register: <https://newsth.live/THEPCFCED> or scan the QR code:



Trials for Bhaichung Bhutia Football Schools today

Bhaichung Bhutia Football Schools (BBFS) will conduct scouting trials in Chennai to identify talented young student-athletes for the BBFS Residential Academy, the organisation's flagship high-performance football training and academic curriculum



in association with reputed boarding schools across India. The trials will take place on April 5 at ANE Sports Arena. Participants are required to report at 8:30 a.m. Footballers born between 2010 and 2015 can participate.

Participants attending the trials must carry a valid government identity card for verification. They are required to report in full football attire, including jerseys, shorts, football boots, and shin guards, which are mandatory for participation. Athletes should also bring a personal hydration pack or water bottle, as the trial session will include high-intensity activities. Registrations can be completed online through the Enjogo app, BBFS's official sports learning and participation platform.

For details, call Siddharth Rawat at 7574980867.



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Travelling long to get inked

Over the last two to three weeks, migrant workers in Chennai have been etching travel plans to vote in their hometowns. Associations representing them are seeking additional trains to ensure their long journey to the voting booth is smooth

LIFFY THOMAS

When election dates were announced on March 15, Kottivakkam resident and general secretary of Confederation of Tamilnadu Malayalee Associations Anwar M.P. was furiously scrolling down IRCTC website to book four train tickets to his hometown in Kannur district of Kerala. A resident of Chennai for the last three decades, the businessman makes travel plans to his native place every election season (that includes panchayat elections) sufficiently ahead of time.

Kerala goes to the hustings on April 9, as do Assam and Puducherry. Further down the “poll procession” are Tamil Nadu (April 23) and West Bengal (April

23 and 29).

Travel plans are being meticulously etched by residents of Chennai with their votes parked in other states. And associations representing the interests of those from these states who have “pitched tent” in Chennai for work and business note that with intervention by the Tamil Nadu government and Southern Railway, these travel plans need not be as stressful as they cur-

Poll-related travel plans are not always about tickets. Soaring prices of flight tickets around this time and lack of certainty about train tickets are encouraging voters to undertake long road trips to cast the ballot

rently are.

The Confederation of Tamilnadu Malayalee Associations has made a representation to the State Government to run additional trains to clear the rush of migrants wanting to vote in their hometowns. “This year, we made the representation more than two months ago so that there is ample time to press more trains into service,” says Anwar.

While Southern Railway does operate special trains during festivals and election season, many say the announcement on additional trains is made at the eleventh hour, which detracts from the usefulness of this exercise.

As Easter, Assembly Polls and Vishu come in quick succession, Anwar says there’s demand for bus and train tickets to Kerala.

Natvar Thidar, aged 44 and working as a cook in Chennai for the last 15 years, notes: “I paid extra money to an agent and got a confirmed ticket on Coromandel Express.”

“There are less number of trains to north Malabar and towards Mangalore, so we have made a representation to run trains on these routes in particular. We also need Vande Bharat on this network,” says Anwar.

A similar demand has been raised by the Assam Association Chennai, they want additional Durgam Express/Rajdhani Express/Vande Bharat Express to Guwahati.

Mini Bengal in Chennai

In Sowcarpet and Park Town, Tarun Kumar Das has been working with the community of Bengalis to encourage them to travel to their hometown to cast their vote. He says there are close to 30,000 Bengalis working mainly with

gold manufacturing outlets. “At least 70% of them have their vote in Bengal and we have already started speaking to them to see if they can start making arrangements to travel home,” says Das, who is vice-president of Rexine and Bag Manufacturer Traders Association - Tamil Nadu and vice-president of the Bengal Association.

Das says the Southern Railway must run additional trains to cater to such rush from people. “The construction industry employs a number of people from Bengal and there should also be some initiative from the industry so that they can also be part of elections,” he adds.

Tamil Nadu Labour Welfare and Skill Development Department has already issued instructions that all employers across industries and commercial establishments, including private sector, shops and factories, must grant paid holiday to employees, casual workers and daily wage earners to travel to their hometowns when voting happens in their states.

‘Vote vandi’

And poll-related travel plans are not always about tickets. Soaring prices of flight tickets around this time and lack of certainty about train tickets are encouraging voters to undertake long road trips to cast the ballot. Increasingly many people are seen coming together to hire a bus or van and travel together. Anwar says he has noticed this trend in the last three years, where people pool in money and book a vehicle that will reach their hometown on voting day and they return on the same bus. Adds Anwar: “They are called ‘vote vandi’ (vote bus).”



ILLUSTRATION SATHEESH VELLINEZHI





PRINCE FREDERICK

Trust a birder to make a short trail longer by taking measured steps, extending their pauses and lingering at every square inch of the landscape, their eyes gulping in ancillary details while scanning for feathers.

Given what they notice at every outing, the local municipal administration should reserve a seat or two for birders at spaces where table-thumping official-citizen interactions over civic affairs, particularly waste management, happen.

Recently, in Chennai, two bird-watchers made a short 400-metre trail along Adyar river in Gandhi Nagar seem longer than the 40,000 kilo-

Garbage on a river trail

Two Chennai residents find themselves carrying out a cleanliness audit of a 400-metre riverside at Gandhi Nagar in Adyar

metre Pan-American Highway.

Both members of Madras Naturalists' Society, Sujatha Padmanabhan (a Teynampet resident) and Jayashree Santhanam (an Adyar resident) had set out on the trail looking for two mi-

grants, an Indian pitta and an Orange-headed thrush that were reportedly haunting that space like the Wiltshire ghost.

They spotted these birds to their delight; and they spotted something else to their dismay. Both the good and the bad have been documented with photographs.

This trail by the side of the Adyar river had its entry point near St. Patrick's School. Talking to *The Hindu Downtown*, Sujatha notes that the path, which is a well-laid

walking track, runs along a fence marking off the river area, and it struts past a park. Sujatha makes it clear that when they started on the walk, they had only birdwatching on their mind. And when they ended it, the pursuit of feathers shared mind space with the idea of an environmental audit of the trail.

Here are the salient features of the report by the duo, enunciated by Sujatha.

"The waste was overwhelmingly non-biodegradable. It was predominantly plastic wrappers, water bottles and disposable containers. This waste was found on the riverside of the fence, and it was sitting on the land near the waters. The location of the garbage makes it largely a case of river-borne accumulation and not one of direct dumping by visitors. Because of its location, this garbage is out of the reach of regular, everyday conservancy operations. But mechanisms have to be devised to clear this garbage, else the risk of biomagnification would shoot up."

While river-borne accumulation seems an explanation that is more than reasonable, going by some of the waste, plastic cups to be precise, it is possible that at night, tipplers sit by the side of the fence to open the bottle and fling the remains of the indulgence over the fence. While the Adyar river (the creek, to be precise) is the diadem in the crown called Tholkappia Poonga, a grand CRRT offering that has indubitably added lustre to the city, it seems odd that parts of the riverside such as this that lie not too far from that grand eco-stage are allowed to wear flannels woven with squalor and neglect.



An Orange-headed thrush (top) and an Indian pitta on a trail along Adyar river in Gandhi Nagar that is overrun with garbage. PHOTOS: SUJATHA PADMANABHAN

'This could be the result of reverse flow'

A Water Resources Department (WRD) official notes that the garbage accumulating at this section of the Adyar river could be the result of reverse flow. His conclusion is predicated on the premise that a cross-boom installed at Kotturpuram would not allow waste flowing in from there to travel to the spot.

On whether WRD can address the issue of waste accumulation at this spot, he notes WRD is allowed to carry out dredging work in the river only around the monsoon.

He notes that GCC clears garbage using the afore-mentioned cross boom, installed during the CRRT project, and the civic body has the machinery to clean this spot too.

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